Mass Polarization and Democratic Decline: Evidence from a Half-Century of Public Opinion

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Abstract

An antagonistic political culture has long been thought to endanger democracy, yet causal evidence for this theory remains limited. I leverage country-year panel estimates of mass polarization and democracy spanning up to 79 countries and 45 years to assess directional effects in a way that has previously not been possible. Results show ideological and affective polarization exhibit negligible causal effects on democracy, and any self-reinforcing feedback between the two is likewise small. Instead, I uncover consistent evidence that democratic backsliding can foment both forms of polarization in the mass public, and observed cross-sectional correlations likely capture stable cross-national differences rather than dynamic within-country effects. Despite widespread concern over the fate of polarized polities, comparative evidence since the onset of democracy's third wave casts doubt on the notion that mass polarization, on its own, threatens democratic regimes.

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Democratic backsliding has supplanted previously common modes of regime change as the predominant form of democratic erosion in the present-day. Outright military *coups d'état*, *autogolpes*, and blatant election fraud have declined in frequency since the late 1970s (Bermeo 2016). Instead, the third reverse wave of democratization is more often characterized by gradual institutional degradation or power-grabs disguised beneath a veneer of legitimacy (Huntington 1991; Lührmann and Lindberg 2019). As events continue to unfold in diverse contexts from Mexico to Moldova and Turkey to Thailand (Kongkirati 2024; Marandici 2024; Sánchez-Talanquer and Greene 2021; Somer 2019), scholars have identified political polarization in the mass public as one likely culprit behind this wave of backsliding.

Although "polarization" is the term favored by contemporary scholars, the notion that deep sociopolitical cleavages could lead to democratic erosion has long been a key tenet of the democracy literature. The potential for polarization to play such a role appears particularly acute because the very divisions that become exacerbated in polarized polities are inherent within democracy itself (Linz 1978; Rustow 1970). When times are good, these divisions may benefit political society by improving representation through strengthened party brands (Lupu 2013) and by encouraging greater government accountability (Bornschier 2019). When times are bad, however, divisions might sow discord (Dahl 1971), prompt crises of governance (Linz 1978), and make party systems unresponsive to voters (Sartori 1976). Such normatively undesirable effects lead scholars to suspect that mass polarization could threaten democracy (Haggard and Kaufman 2021; Levitsky and Ziblatt 2018; Sarsfield et al. 2024).

Although this accounting of events is plausible, scholars have also theorized that backsliding could instigate polarization—rather than, or in addition to, the reverse. These alternative theoretical accounts recognize that elites, not citizens, are the main antagonists in stories of democratic backsliding (Bartels 2023; Berman 2019; Bermeo 2003; Druckman et al. 2023), and they have much to gain from polarizing the electorate over the legitimacy and appropriate functions of democratic institutions (Stokes 2025). Backsliding events are likely to drive a wedge between supporters of the party perpetrating the backsliding and those of the opposition, with each becoming more hard-

ened in their ideological commitments. The former, driven by elite rhetoric painting the opposition as a threat to democracy themselves, might continue to support their preferred party. The latter, aggrieved by anti-democratic actions wielded against them, likewise come to view other partisans as a threat to their political representation and material well-being. When citizens view democratic crises through a partisan lens (Goodman 2022; Simonovits et al. 2022), they are likely to grow more polarized in their policy attitudes and feelings toward the parties (Laebens and Öztürk 2021). The resulting polarization may even trigger a feedback loop: polarization lays the groundwork for elites to take backsliding actions, those actions prompt further polarization, and so forth (McCoy et al. 2018).

To complicate matters further, existing evidence of a relationship between backsliding and polarization—demonstrated primarily through case studies and cross-sectional analyses (e.g. Arbatli and Rosenberg 2021; Orhan 2022; Somer et al. 2021)—is consistent with both theoretical interpretations. Unfortunately, disentangling the direction or presence of causal effects in this research area has been particularly challenging. Previous studies are constrained by data with a restricted spatiotemporal scope, limiting generalizability and making it difficult to separate effects of within-country changes from those of critical junctures or stable country characteristics (Collier and Collier 1991). Such empirical challenges have left our understanding of the complex connections between polarization and democracy unsettled.

By leveraging country-year panels of mass polarization and democracy for as many as 79 countries in each year from 1975-2019, I am able to assess this complex, dynamic relationship with a level of clarity that has eluded prior work. I begin by replicating the familiar cross-sectional correlation between polarization and backsliding. When I move to an analysis of causal direction, however, results consistently indicate that neither ideological nor affective polarization exerts meaningful effects on democracy in the short-run. Although the negligible effects I uncover do accumulate to some extent over time, even the full long-term effects of polarization take more than 35 years to fully materialize. Instead, I document appreciable effects in the reverse direction, suggesting democratic crises fuel ideological and affective polarization in the mass public.

Finally, I directly address the theoretical possibility that polarization and backsliding may be mutually reinforcing by estimating both directional effects in a unified model. I conclude the potential for reciprocal causation is minimal; the effect of polarization on democracy remains negligible, while the reverse effect is consistently strong. This analysis also enables me to demonstrate another reason why correlational associations do not translate into causal ones: Even after accounting for both directional effects, ideological polarization and democracy tend to covary across countries, implying that cross-sectional analyses may mistake stable, between-country differences for dynamic, within-country effects. This pattern is more muted in the case of affective polarization. Its relationship with democracy appears to be driven more by within-country changes than by between-country differences. Taken together, these findings challenge prevailing notions about the role of mass polarization in democratic backsliding, and they suggest efforts to safeguard democracy may be better directed toward constructing resilient, trustworthy institutions than toward reducing polarization (Cella et al. forthcoming; Holliday et al. 2025).

Polarization and Backsliding: Tracing Complex Relationships

Political polarization in comparative perspective has enjoyed renewed attention over the last decade (Gidron et al. 2020; Reiljan et al. 2024; Wagner 2021), and it has long been closely tied to the study of democracy. Landmark studies of democratization and political institutionalization point to a contentious political climate as partially responsible for democratic breakdowns and troubled democratic transitions throughout the mid- to late-twentieth century (Huntington 1968; Linz 1978). As normal politics regress into antagonistic interpersonal or inter-party relations, the peaceful management of competing interests following mutually agreeable rules becomes increasingly difficult (McCoy et al. 2018). In this type of political climate, "the polarization, the centrifugal drives, and the tendency toward irresponsibility and outbidding" place democratic regimes at risk (Linz 1978, p. 24). Contemporary scholars have built on this foundation with a specific eye toward democratic backsliding after the third wave of democratization, advancing both macro-level

accounts and micro-level behavioral explanations for why democratic backsliding frequently appears alongside mass polarization—both ideological and affective forms.

At the macro level, a large collection of case studies documents democratic erosion in polarized polities across diverse regional contexts (Hunter and Power 2019; Kaufman and Haggard 2019; Slater and Arugay 2018). Syntheses of this literature conclude that polarization, left unchecked, is broadly detrimental to democratic governance (Carothers and O'Donohue 2019; Lieberman et al. 2019; Somer and McCoy 2019). Levitsky and Ziblatt (2018) provide a prominent articulation of this view, examining authoritarian behavior by democratically elected leaders—primarily in Latin America and Eastern Europe—and arguing that polarization facilitates the rise of populist politicians who dismantle democratic institutions and erode political norms (see also Haggard and Kaufman 2021).

In this account, polarization operates not only through electoral competition but also through its effects on meso-level institutions such as interest groups, political parties, and the media (Pierson and Schickler 2020). Instead of acting as bulwarks against further polarization and democratic decline, meso-level institutions reinforce those phenomena by aligning with partisan blocs and increasing incentives for politicians to acquiesce to extremists (Roberts 2019). Over time, such dynamics may weaken democratic guardrails and create conditions that permit institutional degradation.

A complementary line of research on micro-level mechanisms offers insight into how mass polarization might feed into these political incentives and increase the likelihood of backsliding. Scholars hypothesize that polarization encourages citizens to vote for more extreme or confrontational candidates (Abramowitz and Webster 2016), decreases their support for democratic norms (Simonovits et al. 2022), and erodes their dedication to accountability (Iyengar and Krupenkin 2018). Polarization heightens voters' willingness to prioritize partisan goals over democratic principles, increasing tolerance for anti-democratic behavior when it advances preferred outcomes (Graham and Svolik 2020; Svolik 2020). Similarly, Kingzette et al. (2021) argue that affective polarization generates asymmetric democratic preferences, such that partisans oppose constitu-

tional protections when their party is in power and support such measures when they are out of power (Finkel et al. 2020). In sum, this literature suggests a causal chain in which mass polarization erodes democratic attitudes, permits elite misconduct, and ultimately leads to democratic backsliding.

However, an underappreciated implication emerging from this same literature is that perceived or actual democratic crises could exacerbate or even foment mass polarization, rather than the reverse. Such accounts center on the observation that backsliding is driven not by the general public, but by political elites who possess the access to state power and control over institutions that would be necessary to coordinate legal and extralegal changes (Bartels 2023; Berman 2019; Druckman 2024; Grillo and Prato 2023; Haggard and Kaufman 2021). Would-be autocrats have a strong incentive to instigate polarization around a democratic cleavage (Corrales and Salas Díaz forthcoming; Stokes 2025). By portraying institutions as dysfunctional and partisan opponents as existential threats (Laebens and Öztürk 2021), elites can justify their own anti-democratic actions as being necessary to preserve order (Braley et al. 2023). Opposing parties frequently respond in kind (Haggard and Kaufman 2021; Somer et al. 2021), drawing clear partisan lines over the very meaning of democracy, whether it is broken, and how to fix it (Goodman 2022).

Elites' ability to activate party-democracy cleavages likely stems from how citizens process political information. Citizens typically lack detailed knowledge on complex political issues (e.g. Converse 1964), so they rely on cues from preferred political elites to make sense of them (Lenz 2012). Conflicts over democracy are no different; democracy is inherently contested, requiring ongoing negotiation between values such as freedom and equality or majority rule and minority rights (Dahl 1971; Lijphart 1984). Somer and McCoy (2018, p. 6) describe polarization as a "consequence of crises rooted in democracy's internal tensions and contradictions" (see also Sarsfield et al. 2024). Democratic crises are therefore likely to be viewed by citizens through a partisan lens (Goodman 2022; Simonovits et al. 2022), with the incumbent party or coalition seen as the aggressor (or rightful reformer) and the others seen as the victims (or threats to be guarded against).

When party identity is strong, citizens also engage in partisan-motivated reasoning. They uncritically accept political messages that comport with their partisan commitments and reject those that do not (Lodge and Taber 2013). Krishnarajan (2023) shows that citizens rationalize democratic out-party actions as illegitimate, while excusing in-party norm violations as justified. Because democratic conflicts cut to the core of citizens' relationship to the political system and they view those conflicts as partisans, such disputes are especially likely to intensify partisan affect.

Historical evidence reinforces this elite-centered view. In her analysis of interwar Europe and mid-twentieth century South America, Bermeo (2003) finds little indication that ordinary citizens defected to extremist parties or abandoned the political center prior to democratic collapse. Instead, breakdowns reflected leadership failure and elite misperceptions of public opinion. Similar patterns appear in contemporary Europe, where democratic crises have unfolded despite stable mass attitudes toward democracy and far-right parties over the past two decades (Bartels 2023). In fact, these crises occurred following party *convergence* and partisan *dealignment* in the late twentieth century (Berman and Kundnani 2021; Dalton and Wattenberg 2000).

Accounts emphasizing economic dislocation reach similar conclusions. Stokes (2025) argues that rising income inequality engendered by late-1900s globalization produced large numbers of voters who felt left behind economically and unrepresented politically (see also Morgan 2011). These disillusioned voters were thus were receptive to anti-establishment appeals from both left- and right-wing parties. In this framework, mass polarization is not the underlying cause of democratic erosion, but rather a *byproduct* of elite strategies to consolidate power and justify institutional capture.[1]

As an illustrative example, consider how this process unfolded in Venezuela. Economic decline and rising inequality played a role in voters' disaffection from the party system and subsequent turn to Hugo Chávez (Coppedge 2005), but mass polarization did not initially map onto class divisions (Myers 1998). Instead, polarization increased most rapidly *after* Chávez began dismantling repre-

[1]Importantly, this theoretical account does not entirely preclude the micro-level arguments made by Graham and Svolik (2020), Kingzette et al. (2021), and others. If polarization makes voters more willing to tolerate norm violations by co-partisan elites, it could still help sustain existing backsliding episodes without necessarily being the proximate cause (Ahmed 2023).

sentative institutions. Democracy itself became the central axis of polarization, with social groups adopting divergent understandings of democratic legitimacy in response to repeated norm violations (García-Guadilla and Mallen 2019; McCoy and Diez 2011). Everyday choices such as the food one chose to eat or where one chose to shop became laden with political meaning, transforming political disagreement into moralized social antagonism (Mallen and García-Guadilla 2017; Roberts 2003). Scholars highlight similar dynamics in Greece (Stavrakakis 2018), South Africa (Southall 2019), Turkey (Laebens and Öztürk 2021), and several Asian democracies (Slater and Arugay 2018). Taken together, existing scholarship suggests the connection between polarization and backsliding is complex, with each likely contributing to the other. Untangling this causal web is my empirical objective.

Causal Models of Polarization and Democracy

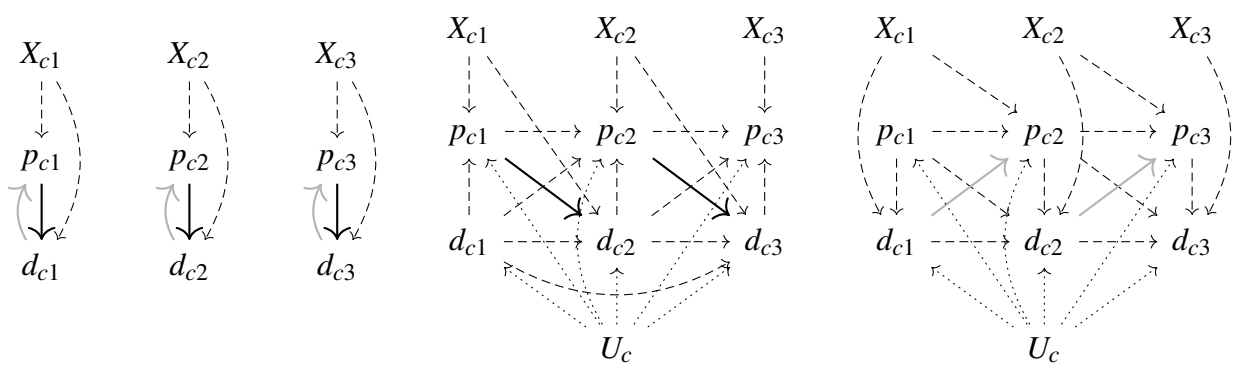
Existing accounts of polarization and democracy are hard-pressed to identify a generalizable causal effect. Observational studies typically focus on specific cases or regions (McCoy et al. 2018; Slater and Arugay 2018), raising questions about external validity. Even large-N studies are constrained by data availability (Orhan 2022; Somer et al. 2021), as cross-national survey programs yield an inconsistent patchwork of data across time and space (Claassen 2019; Mehlhaff 2025). With only a handful of country-year observations for each case (Gidron et al. 2020; Reiljan et al. 2024), measuring temporal change is difficult, and explaining it is even more so. Before describing how I leverage data that overcome these challenges, I first delineate the effects I seek to identify and the modeling framework I use to do so.

Figure 1, panel (a) depicts the sort of cross-sectional relationship scholars are currently equipped to estimate. The solid black lines indicate the effect of polarization, p_{ct}, on democracy, d_{ct}, in country c at time t—the primary quantity of interest. That relationship is confounded by covariates, X_{ct}, which conceivably affect both p_{ct} and d_{ct}, indicated by dashed lines. Because these analyses are cross-sectional, each time period is isolated from the others. It is therefore im-

possible to know whether scholars have identified the black arrow linking p_{ct} to d_{ct} or the gray arrow linking d_{ct} back to p_{ct}. This simple cross-sectional model is expressed in (1), where α is an intercept, δ gives the non-causal effect of polarization on democracy, $\boldsymbol{\gamma}$ is a vector of coefficients on covariates, and ε_{ct} is random error:

$$d_{ct} = \alpha + \delta p_{ct} + \boldsymbol{\gamma}\mathbf{X}_{ct} + \varepsilon_{ct}. \tag{1}$$

I fit this model using ordinary least squares (OLS) to establish, in line with previous work, that polarization correlates with democracy. The effect of interest, δ, should therefore carry a negative sign. However, this effect should be interpreted as purely correlational. A cross-sectional analysis can demonstrate only that higher levels of polarization are observed alongside lower levels of democracy in a given country-year. Left unanswered is whether this correlation is due to variation *within* countries or *across* them.



(a) Cross-sectional (unidentified) (b) Causal (polarization → democracy) (c) Causal (democracy → polarization)

Figure 1: Directed Cyclic and Acyclic Graphs of Polarization-Democracy Relationships. X_{ct}, p_{ct}, d_{ct}, and U_c denote covariates, polarization, level of democracy, and unobserved effects in country c at time t. Solid arrows represent key effects of interest, dashed arrows represent effects of observed variables, and dotted arrows represent effects of unobserved variables.

Indeed, the complex theoretical relationships linking polarization to democracy present several challenges that make cross-sectional analysis inappropriate for identifying a causal effect. First, as discussed above, democratic backsliding may exhibit reciprocal causation with mass polarization. Temporally frequent observations of polarization and democracy can help separate these effects.

Second, the effect of any variable on democracy is likely to be delayed. In line with other scholars (Acemoglu et al. 2009; Boix 2011), I assume explanatory variables affect only *future* levels of democracy, not present ones. Third, polarization and democracy are likely persistent over time, with the state of each variable at time t directly affected by its state at time $t-1$. This temporal persistence is particularly acute for levels of democracy, which may exhibit second-order temporal dependence (Claassen 2020; Teorell 2010). Finally, each country's experience with democracy is idiosyncratically affected by unobserved variables. Countries may experience critical junctures that affect their path to democratization, influence their long-term political culture, or shape key institutions (Collier and Collier 1991; North 1990).

To account for such considerations, Figure 1, panel (b) incorporates these relationships using a directed acyclic graph. U_c denotes unobserved, time-invariant effects in country c. All other variables remain defined as in panel (a). The solid black arrow still signifies the primary quantity of interest: the effect of polarization on democracy. Formally expressing the relationships shown in Figure 1, panel (b) yields a dynamic fixed effects model similar to those common in other studies of democracy (Acemoglu et al. 2008; Boix 2011; Haber and Menaldo 2011). This model is expressed in (2), where β_1 and β_2 indicate lagged effects of the dependent variable, U_c represents country fixed effects, and all other terms are defined as in (1):

$$d_{ct} = \delta p_{c,t-1} + \beta_1 d_{c,t-1} + \beta_2 d_{c,t-2} + \boldsymbol{\gamma}\mathbf{X}_{c,t-1} + U_c + \varepsilon_{ct}. \tag{2}$$

In this specification, δ can be interpreted as the change in democracy at time t due to polarization at time $t-1$.

Finally, Figure 1, panel (c) presents a similar graph as in panel (b), but this one identifies the causal effect of changes in the level of democracy on the degree of mass polarization. This directional effect is denoted by the solid gray arrow, similar to panel (a). I only assume first-order temporal dependence for polarization, so this model requires only one β term:

$$p_{ct} = \delta d_{c,t-1} + \beta p_{c,t-1} + \boldsymbol{\gamma}\mathbf{X}_{c,t-1} + U_c + \varepsilon_{ct}. \tag{3}$$

Here, δ describes the change in polarization at time t due to democracy levels at time $t-1$.

Models such as those in (2) and (3) present another difficulty: The lagged dependent variables will be correlated with ε_{ct} when the number of units (in this case, the number of countries C) is larger than the number of time periods T (Keele and Kelly 2006; Nickell 1981), violating standard exogeneity assumptions. To ameliorate this bias, I employ a system generalized methods of moments (GMM) estimator with heteroskedasticity-consistent standard errors (Windmeijer 2005). The system GMM estimator uses an additional dependent variable lag as an instrumental variable (Hansen 1982), relying on the assumption that these earlier values influence the lagged outcomes but are not correlated with ε_{ct}.[2]

A Note on Identification and Assumptions

Identification in this case does not rely on exogenous variation in polarization or democracy, but rather on polarization (democracy) being unrelated to any changes in democracy (polarization) that were not already predicted by recent history and covariates. The counterfactual for the effect of $p_{c,t-1}$ on d_{ct} is thus a country that had the same past democratic trajectory and covariates, but experienced different polarization levels at $t-1$ for reasons unrelated to the factors that determine subsequent democratic change.

Under the identification strategy and modeling framework above, estimates of δ in (2) and (3) have causal interpretations under three assumptions (Imai and Kim 2019). First, dependent variable lags used as instruments do not affect present levels of the dependent variable, except by acting through more temporally proximate levels or observed covariates.[3] Second, the explanatory variable affects the dependent variable only through the specified lag structure; the effects from periods prior to the included lags do not carry over into the current one. Third, the key explanatory variable is unrelated to ε_{ct} after conditioning on covariates, fixed effects, and past values of the dependent variable. This also implies that actors do not anticipate future changes to the dependent

[2]See Wawro (2002) for an overview and Claassen (2020), Milner and Mukherjee (2009), and Quinn and Toyoda (2007), among others, for applied examples.

[3]For example, $d_{c,t-3}$ has no direct effect on d_{ct}. Instead, $d_{c,t-3}$ affects $d_{c,t-2}$ and $d_{c,t-1}$, which affect d_{ct} in turn.

variable. Although not required for identification per se, the system GMM estimator additionally requires that deviations from a country's long-run level of the dependent variable are unrelated to the time-invariant characteristics captured by fixed effects.

Conditional on these assumptions, I am able to go a step further than "Granger causality" (Freeman 1983; Granger 1969), which would indicate temporal ordering but not necessarily causal structure. Nevertheless, although I can take steps to mitigate threats to the validity of these assumptions, I cannot entirely eliminate them. For instance, I cannot completely rule out the possibility that polarization and democracy are jointly determined by some unobserved, long-evolving political process occurring within countries over time.[4]

These limitations reflect the broader difficulty of achieving clean causal identification of the polarization-democracy relationship, where experimental manipulation at the macro-level is neither practical nor ethical and plausibly exogenous natural experiments are rare. While my approach does not fully resolve these challenges, it does offer stronger grounds for causal inference than the cross-sectional comparisons that have thus far dominated the literature.

Data

Mass Polarization

Rapid growth in scholarly interest has spawned a proliferation of datasets measuring mass polarization across countries and over time (Boxell et al. 2024; Orhan 2022; Reiljan et al. 2024). Unfortunately, most of these datasets are not well-suited to testing the connection between polarization and democracy. Unraveling the complex relationships posited in the preceding sections requires data that are temporally frequent and spatially broad. Moreover, these data should ideally be country *panels* of polarization and democracy, not merely repeated cross-sections.

[4] I show in Supplementary Information (SI) section S8, however, that results are unlikely to be threatened by unobserved time-variant confounders.

Most existing datasets capture only affective polarization—ignoring more ideological forms—and they do so by employing measurement strategies that can lead to conceptually inappropriate polarization estimates (Mehlhaff 2024). More critically, data is scarce; existing studies of comparative polarization most commonly draw their raw survey data from the Comparative Study of Electoral Systems, which provides between one and six observations per country (Gidron et al. 2020; Wagner 2021). Occasionally, scholars cast a wider net, collating data from multiple national election studies to expand the pool of country-years (e.g. Garzia et al. 2023). Doing so requires care, however; surveys vary in how they phrase questions and response options, the same item can be interpreted differently across contexts (Stegmueller 2011), and survey programs employ different sampling strategies and fieldwork protocols. Such sources of variation must be corrected for if surveys are to be fruitfully combined, and doing so would still yield only a handful of observations for each case, inconsistently spaced across time. Causal identification is difficult to achieve under such circumstances.

Instead, I draw estimates of ideological and affective polarization from the Polarization in Comparative Attitudes Project (PolarCAP; Mehlhaff 2025). PolarCAP also aggregates many surveys—about 3.5 million observations across 35 survey programs—but it then uses latent variable models to estimate country-year panels of polarization by correcting for the types of non-stochastic variation mentioned above (see also Claassen 2019). These models also smooth over time, meaning they estimate polarization at every time point, even when no raw survey data exists in a given country-year. PolarCAP draws on assessments of left-right self-placement and party affect to estimate ideological and affective polarization, respectively. The former captures the extent to which citizens are divided into ideologically distinct groups, while the latter captures the extent to which citizens feel positively toward some parties, feel negatively toward others, and share those assessments with their fellow partisans.

I use yearly estimates of ideological polarization for 79 countries and of affective polarization for 49 countries.[5] I begin both time series in 1975—the year Huntington (1991) identified as the

[5] Affective polarization estimates are available for fewer countries owing to the more limited availability of survey data on party affect.

start of the third wave—and end them in 2019, the final year for which polarization estimates are currently available. These polarization data confer at least three important advantages over past studies. First, as quantitative measures, they display greater fidelity to the conceptual understanding of polarization, where intergroup heterogeneity and intragroup homogeneity are both important (Esteban and Ray 1994; Fortunato and Stevenson 2021; Mehlhaff 2024). Second, the broad spatiotemporal scope facilitates generalizable inferences. Finally, having yearly panel estimates enables causal tests using time series methods like the ones I describe above.

Level of Democracy

In contrast to other forms of regime change, democratic backsliding implies a slow degeneration of democratic institutions and restrictions on civil liberties; it does not necessarily occur in clear, episodic breaks. Ideal for analyzing backsliding would therefore be a fully continuous measure sensitive enough to respond to gradual declines in level or quality of democracy (Lührmann and Lindberg 2019). However, scholars highlight many different dimensions and subtypes of democracy (Collier and Levitsky 1997) and backsliding can occur through different channels (Bermeo 2016). I therefore use three different measures to approach the concept from multiple angles.

I take the first two from the Varieties of Democracy (V-Dem) project (Coppedge et al. 2020). V-Dem draws more than four hundred indicators from factual information and evaluations by country-expert coders and aggregates them into theoretically distinct dimensions of democracy. The electoral dimension is closely tied to the concept of polyarchy (Dahl 1971). It gauges "competition for the approval of a broad electorate during periodic elections." The liberal dimension, by contrast, captures things like "constitutionally protected civil liberties, strong rule of law, and effective checks and balances that limit the use of executive power" (Lindberg et al. 2014, p. 160). The electoral and liberal democracy dimensions are well-positioned to capture backsliding through electoral manipulation and executive aggrandizement, respectively, so I evaluate them both.

Scholars enthusiastically debate the merits of measures like V-Dem—which rely on assessments of individual coders—relative to more "objective" indicators such as incumbent party dom-

inance or executive constraints (Cheibub et al. 2010; Weitzel et al. forthcoming). Little and Meng (2024) provide a summary measure which incorporates twelve indicators into a simple additive index, including aspects like the proportion of the population with suffrage, the degree of legislative competitiveness, and violations in electoral processes.[6] I include this index as a complement to V-Dem's more comprehensive measures. Because they are primarily suitable for detecting large, clearly observable changes in the status of a country's institutions (Miller 2024), the objective indicators provide a sense of whether polarization may be connected to wholesale changes in a country's regime, rather than the more gradual form of backsliding captured by V-Dem indices. Combining these three measures of democracy with PolarCAP measures of mass polarization, all of which are available on a yearly basis, allows for a fine-grained analysis of polarization and democratic backsliding over time and across countries. Supplementary Information (SI) section S1 lists all countries used in analyses, as well as which types of polarization and democracy data are available for each.

Control Variables

I identify four variables that may confound the target effects in Figure 1, panels (b) and (c). First, party system fragmentation may reduce polarization by inhibiting the formation of cohesive partisan blocs (Reiljan et al. 2024), while also increasing democratic gridlock and incentives for executive aggrandizement (Tsebelis 2002). I account for this using the effective number of parties (Bormann and Golder 2022). Second, economic development is associated with democratic survival (Przeworski et al. 2000) and features prominently in accounts of polarization driven by economic crisis (McCoy et al. 2018). I therefore include logged GDP per capita for each country-year (*World Development Indicators* 2021). Third, several theories link democracy and polarization to economic inequality (McCarty et al. 2006; Stokes 2025), so I include disposable income inequality (post-tax, post-transfer) as measured by the Gini coefficient (Solt 2020). Fourth, dependency on natural resources may undermine democratic durability (Ross 2001). I capture this using total nat-

[6] I break this index into its component parts in SI section S5.

ural resource rents as a share of GDP (*World Development Indicators* 2021).[7] Other institutional configurations, such as presidentialism or majoritarian electoral systems, could also impact both polarization and democracy. Since these variables are typically constant over time, however, I cannot control for them directly, as any variation they would explain is already absorbed by country fixed effects.

The Negligible Causal Effect of Polarization on Democracy

I begin by fitting the cross-sectional OLS model in (1) to assess the degree to which polarization is correlated with level of democracy. All real-valued variables are unit-normalized, so all parameter estimates can be interpreted in terms of standard deviations. Estimates of $\hat{\delta}$, presented in Table 1, imply that mass polarization is negatively associated with democracy, with a one standard deviation increase in polarization corresponding to a decrease in democracy of up to 0.102 standard deviations. This effect is statistically distinguishable from zero at the $\alpha = 0.05$ level across all but one combination of democracy and polarization variables. These results are consistent with previous studies of polarization and democracy, offering additional empirical support for their co-occurrence and increasing confidence that the yearly measures used here capture substantively meaningful patterns observed in prior work.

However, applying the causal model in Figure 1, panel (b) begins to change the picture. Table 2 presents results of the system GMM models used to fit (2). All but one estimate of $\hat{\delta}$ still carry negative signs, but none of them achieve statistical significance at the same $\alpha = 0.05$ level. Further, most point estimates of $\hat{\delta}$ are substantially smaller than in the cross-sectional model, with a one standard deviation increase in polarization now leading to a decrease in democracy of, at most, 0.013 standard deviations—a decrease in effect size of between 84 and 99 percent when comparing system GMM to cross-sectional estimates.[8] All Arellano-Bond and Hansen-Sargan test statistics

[7] Since natural resource rents seem likely to affect democracy but not polarization, controlling for them is not necessary for identification. However, including them can still increase the precision of the estimates.

[8] $\hat{\delta}$ actually increases in magnitude in the models testing objective democratic indicators and affective polarization, but neither model's estimate is statistically significant.

Table 1: Cross-Sectional Models of Polarization and Democracy

	Dependent variable:					
	Electoral		Liberal		Objective	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Ideological	-0.095^*		-0.083^*		-0.081^*	
	(0.018)		(0.018)		(0.029)	
Affective		-0.029^*		-0.028^*		-0.010
		(0.011)		(0.011)		(0.023)
Eff. Parties	0.023	0.159	0.050	0.159	0.091	0.053
	(0.105)	(0.095)	(0.099)	(0.095)	(0.130)	(0.146)
GDP	0.596^*	0.802^*	0.662^*	0.881^*	0.131	0.209
	(0.061)	(0.064)	(0.064)	(0.064)	(0.079)	(0.141)
Gini	0.028	0.107^*	-0.023	0.073	0.105	0.105
	(0.053)	(0.053)	(0.053)	(0.056)	(0.078)	(0.100)
Resources	-0.071	-0.233^*	-0.071	-0.230^*	-0.095^*	-0.165
	(0.043)	(0.093)	(0.050)	(0.108)	(0.043)	(0.111)
Intercept	0.122^*	-0.056	0.084	-0.073	0.110^*	0.036
	(0.046)	(0.058)	(0.049)	(0.060)	(0.053)	(0.095)
Observations	3,250	2,054	3,250	2,054	2,807	1,811
R^2	0.488	0.518	0.579	0.596	0.037	0.032
Adjusted R^2	0.487	0.517	0.578	0.595	0.035	0.029

Note: $^*p < 0.05$. Clustered standard errors in parentheses. All real-valued variables unit-normalized.

are insignificant, indicating the GMM instruments are successful in partialling out second-order serial correlation, so these null results are likely not an artifact of slow-moving dependent variables.

It is noteworthy that estimates are consistent across dependent variables. Grillo et al. (2024) theorize that mass polarization increases the likelihood of electoral manipulation but could decrease the risk of executive aggrandizement. However, Table 2 provides minimal evidence for such a distinction. In SI section S4, I use data on discrete backsliding events (Baron et al. 2024)

Table 2: System GMM Models of Polarization and Democracy

	Dependent variable:					
	Electoral		Liberal		Objective	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Ideological$_{t-1}$	−0.005		−0.005		−0.013	
	(0.003)		(0.003)		(0.011)	
Affective$_{t-1}$		0.0003		−0.002		−0.016
		(0.003)		(0.004)		(0.013)
Democracy$_{t-1}$	1.203*	1.204*	1.246*	1.221*	0.997*	0.912*
	(0.036)	(0.056)	(0.029)	(0.052)	(0.038)	(0.064)
Democracy$_{t-2}$	−0.266*	−0.354*	−0.302*	−0.325*	−0.158*	−0.163*
	(0.033)	(0.044)	(0.030)	(0.050)	(0.027)	(0.036)
Eff. Parties$_{t-1}$	−0.020*	0.001	−0.015	−0.002	−0.006	0.006
	(0.010)	(0.017)	(0.009)	(0.013)	(0.023)	(0.037)
GDP$_{t-1}$	0.036*	0.110*	0.035*	0.084*	0.010	0.049
	(0.012)	(0.037)	(0.013)	(0.036)	(0.017)	(0.032)
Gini$_{t-1}$	0.005	0.012	0.0005	0.006	0.016	0.014
	(0.005)	(0.008)	(0.005)	(0.007)	(0.012)	(0.018)
Resources$_{t-1}$	−0.009	−0.033	−0.006	−0.023	−0.033*	−0.040
	(0.006)	(0.022)	(0.005)	(0.018)	(0.012)	(0.031)
N Observations	3,107	1,963	3,107	1,963	2,667	1,718
N Units	79	49	79	49	76	49
N Time Periods	43	43	43	43	38	38
Arellano-Bond Z	−0.853	−0.733	−1.152	−1.885	−0.816	−0.623
Hansen-Sargan χ^2	72.743	44.176	74.182	47.324	69.173	41.873

Note: $^*p < 0.05$. Heteroskedasticity-consistent standard errors in parentheses. All real-valued variables unit-normalized.

to show that distinguishing between attacks on vertical and horizontal accountability structures is similarly inconsequential.

The Supplementary Information also presents a variety of auxiliary analyses. First, I fit pooled OLS models that lack a causal interpretation but require fewer assumptions, as well as quasi-Poisson models of discrete backsliding events in sections S3 and S4, respectively. All results are substantively similar. Second, I break down the index of objective indicators into its component parts in section S5. While most effects are still statistically indistinguishable from zero, polarization does have a small negative effect on a handful of variables, such as electoral competition. Third, I remove any countries that experienced coups during the time period under consideration. Results in section S6 are nearly identical to those in Table 2. Fourth, it is important to consider measurement error when using latent variables in downstream analyses (Caughey and Warshaw 2018; Tai et al. 2024). In section S7.3, I show that propagating uncertainty from the polarization and democracy measures into the effect estimates does not change the substantive conclusions. Finally, in section S8.1, I show it is extremely unlikely that these results are vulnerable to unobserved confounding. An additional explanatory variable would need to be, at minimum, 34 times more prognostic than any variable currently in the model in order to overturn this insignificant result.

Testing for Negligible Effects

Analyses above suggest the observed relationship between mass polarization and democratic backsliding is primarily correlational and the causal effect is more muted. However, statistically insignificant parameter estimates are not themselves evidence of a negligible effect. The null hypothesis significance tests in Table 2 demonstrate only that the data are *consistent* with polarization having no effect on democracy. To argue for a negligible effect, I need to demonstrate that the data are *inconsistent* with polarization having any meaningful effect on democracy. Confidence intervals which include zero are not sufficient evidence for such a claim because they could merely reflect low statistical power and do not rule out effects that could, in fact, be meaningful (Doucette 2025; Gill 1999).

Instead, I use a two-step procedure for demonstrating evidence of a negligible effect (Rainey 2014): First, identify how large an effect must be in order to be considered meaningful and state a

hypothesis for testing whether the effect rises to that level. Second, construct a 90% equal-tailed confidence interval for the effect estimate to test the hypothesis (Berger and Hsu 1996).[9] If the effect size identified as meaningful lies entirely outside the confidence interval, the data can be interpreted as being inconsistent with any meaningful effect.

As a benchmark for meaningful effect sizes, I calculate the standard deviation of each democracy indicator within each country and identify the most stable democracies over the time period under consideration.[10] In the case of both electoral and liberal democracy, Sweden displays the least change over time. From 1975 to 2019, Sweden's levels of electoral and liberal democracy have standard deviations of 0.038 and 0.042, respectively.[11] Switzerland experiences the least change according to the objective measure, with an over-time standard deviation of 0.147.[12] Democracy in Sweden and Switzerland is so stable that its fluctuations over time likely represent little more than measurement uncertainty. At a minimum, effects of polarization should be able to clear these thresholds in order to be considered meaningful. This implies a set of hypotheses:

$$\begin{aligned} H_0: &\quad \delta \in (-\infty, -\tau] \cup [\tau, \infty), \\ H_1: &\quad \delta \in (-\tau, \tau), \end{aligned} \tag{4}$$

where δ is the effect size and τ is the threshold for a meaningful effect size—0.038 in the case of electoral democracy, 0.042 in the case of liberal democracy, and 0.147 in the case of objective indicators. Therefore, if the 90% confidence interval for the effect size does not contain τ, I should reject the null hypothesis that polarization has a meaningful effect on democracy in favor of the alternate hypothesis that polarization has a negligible effect on democracy.

[9] A 90% confidence interval is equivalent to conducting two one-sided tests at $\alpha = 0.05$, the significance level I use in all other analyses.

[10] Each democracy indicator is unit-normalized, so they can be directly compared to model parameter estimates.

[11] Contrast these estimates to those of the most volatile country, Chile, whose electoral and liberal democracy estimates display standard deviations of 1.36 and 1.27, respectively.

[12] The most volatile is Bulgaria, with a standard deviation of 1.96.

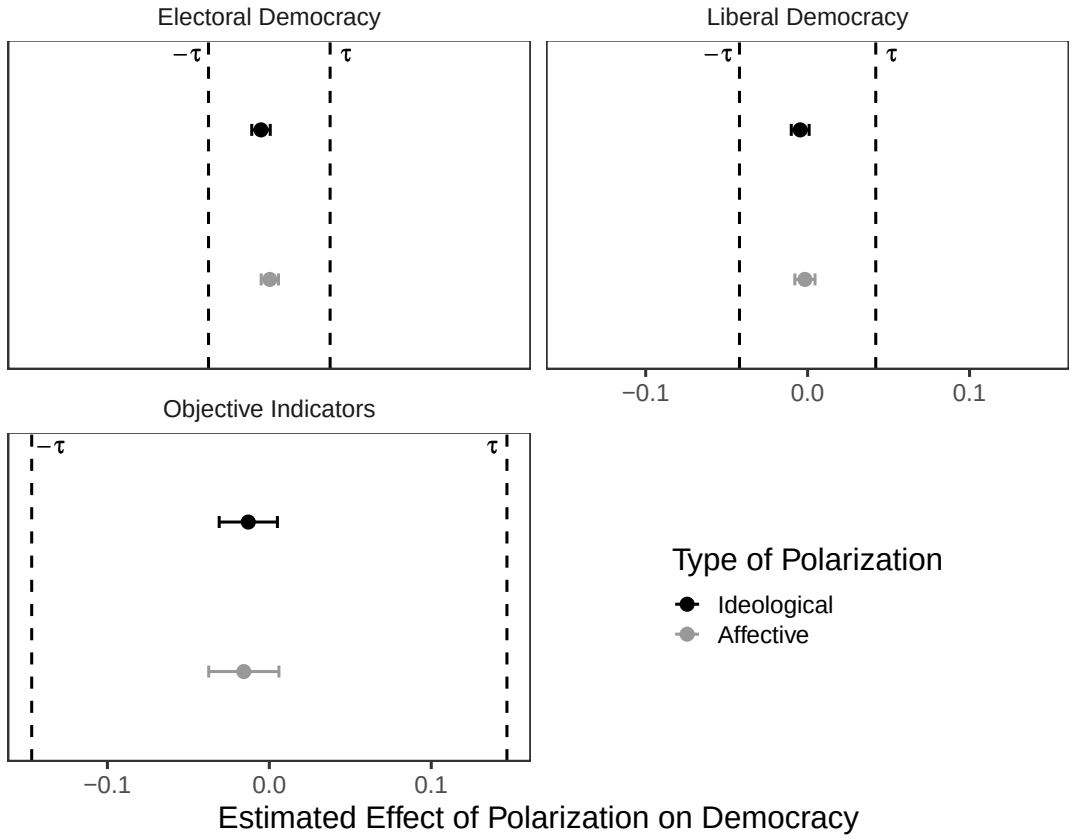


Figure 2: Testing for a Negligible Effect of Polarization on Democracy. Point estimates correspond to δ in (2), as displayed in Table 2. Error bars give 90% confidence intervals. Dotted lines represent $-\tau$ and τ for each dimension of democracy.

Figure 2 displays these 90% confidence intervals. Dashed vertical lines indicate $-\tau$ and τ, the values outside which polarization could be interpreted as having a meaningful effect on democracy. Clearly, all confidence intervals are well within these thresholds, regardless of the type of polarization or dimension of democracy. Thus, I reject H_0 in favor of H_1 and conclude that mass polarization does, indeed, have a negligible effect on level of democracy.

Long-Run Effects

So far, I have investigated only *short-run* effects. The effects of polarization could be cumulative; polarization at time $t-1$ could exert a small effect on democracy at time t but nevertheless con-

tribute to a snowballing effect over time, resulting in larger changes in democracy at time $t+1$, $t+2$, and so on. To investigate this possibility, I use the long-run multiplier:

$$\mathrm{LR}_{p_c} = \frac{\hat{\delta}}{1-(\hat{\beta}_1+\hat{\beta}_2)}, \tag{5}$$

where $\hat{\delta}$ denotes the estimate for the coefficient on polarization and $\hat{\beta}_1$ and $\hat{\beta}_2$ denote the estimates for the coefficients on lagged democracy (De Boef and Keele 2008).

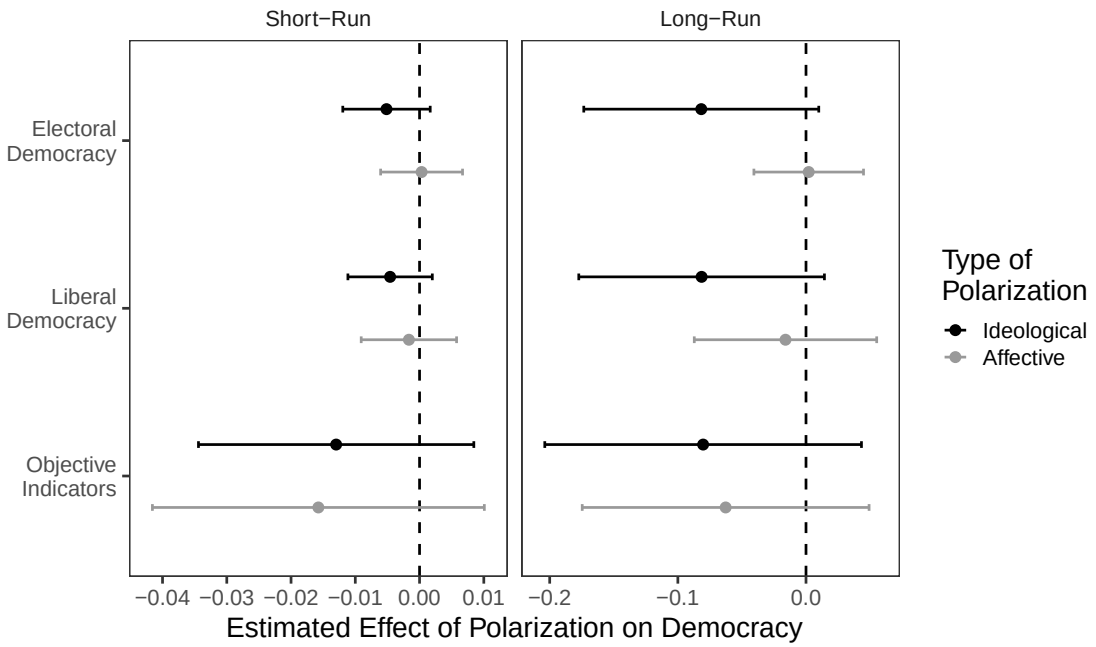


Figure 3: Short-Run and Long-Run Effects of Polarization on Democracy. Short-run point estimates are taken from Table 2. Long-run point estimates are calculated using (5). Error bars give 95% confidence intervals.

Figure 3 displays the estimated short- and long-run effects of polarization on democracy using estimates from Table 2. Error bars give 95% confidence intervals. An increase in polarization level does appear to accumulate over time; estimates of long-run effects are 4 to 18 times larger than short-run effects. However, none of these long-run effects are statistically distinguishable from zero. Cumulative effect sizes of a one standard deviation increase in level of polarization range from 0.001 to 0.08 standard deviations; four of the six long-run point effects are still below the minimum effect thresholds from Figure 2. Moreover, this effect assumes the shock to polarization

is *permanent*. Although this assumption is helpful for comparing immediate and delayed effects, it almost certainly does not hold in reality, implying that the long-run effect is not likely to be fully realized.

Even assuming this condition is a reasonable approximation of the real world, the total long-run effect shown in Figure 3 is distributed over an arbitrarily long period of time. To find *how long* this effect takes to transpire, I calculate the number of years required for the cumulative effect of the polarization shock to reach 50% and 95% of the total effect. The shock to ideological polarization produces 50% of its total effect within 4 to 9 years, depending on the dimension of democracy. Affective polarization effects are more muted, but they accumulate more quickly, needing only 3 to 5 years to reach half their total value. These are reasonable time horizons, but consider that the total long-run effect was, in many cases, still quite small. Realizing only half that effect implies an impact that is much smaller still.

Due to non-linear decay, the accumulation of each effect slows down over time. Effects of ideological polarization do not begin to approach their asymptote (95% of the total long-run effect) for 14 to 35 years, and effects of affective polarization require 8 to 17 years to fully materialize. In all cases, the objective democracy indicators are affected more quickly than either of the more comprehensive electoral or liberal democracy measures. Although more dramatic than short-run effects, the long-term effects of polarization on democracy do not appear to be appreciable overall. Even in the case of ideological polarization, which has slightly stronger effects than affective polarization, the time horizon at which those effects fully materialize is beyond the temporal scope with which social scientists are often concerned.

Reversing the Causal Arrow: Polarization as an Outcome of Democratic Crisis

Results above suggest that on a purely cross-sectional basis, mass polarization has a negative, statistically significant effect on democracy. This finding is in line with much existing work on the

topic, including many case studies and qualitative accounts. However, they also suggest that mass polarization *causes* virtually no change in democracy. Neither ideological nor affective polarization appear to directly cause backsliding via electoral manipulation or executive aggrandizement, nor do they seem to have meaningful effects on the observable presence of democratic institutions. If so many scholarly accounts intimately link these two phenomena and large-N cross-sectional analyses confirm this correlation, why is the estimated causal effect negligible?

One possibility is that scholars have correctly identified a causal relationship between polarization and democracy, but they have been mistaken about the *direction* of that effect. I previously highlighted some theoretical reasons to believe democratic crisis could contribute to mass polarization. Past studies reveal this temporal sequencing in some of the most high-profile cases of polarization and backsliding (e.g. Mallen and García-Guadilla 2017; Southall 2019). Returning to Figure 1, panel (a), this explanation implies the cross-sectional relationship is primarily driven by the solid gray arrow, but common accounts may have mistaken it for the solid black arrow.

To assess this eventuality, I turn to the inverse causal relationship and evaluate the extent to which democratic backsliding foments mass polarization. This effect is exemplified by the solid gray arrow in Figure 1, panel (c) and expressed formally in (3). As stated above, I assume polarization exhibits only first-order temporal dependence. The system GMM models therefore contain one lagged dependent variable and are instrumented with the second lag. Insignificant Arellano-Bond and Hansen-Sargan test statistics indicate this specification is generally sufficient for eliminating serial correlation, and further dependent variable lags are therefore not necessary. Figure 4 displays the estimated short- and long-run effects of democracy on polarization, with the long-run multiplier now given by:

$$\mathrm{LR}_{d_c} = \frac{\hat{\delta}}{1-\hat{\beta}}, \tag{6}$$

where $\hat{\delta}$ and $\hat{\beta}$ denote parameter estimates from the model in (3).[13] As in Figure 3, error bars provide 95% confidence intervals.

[13] SI section S2 presents full results in tabular form.

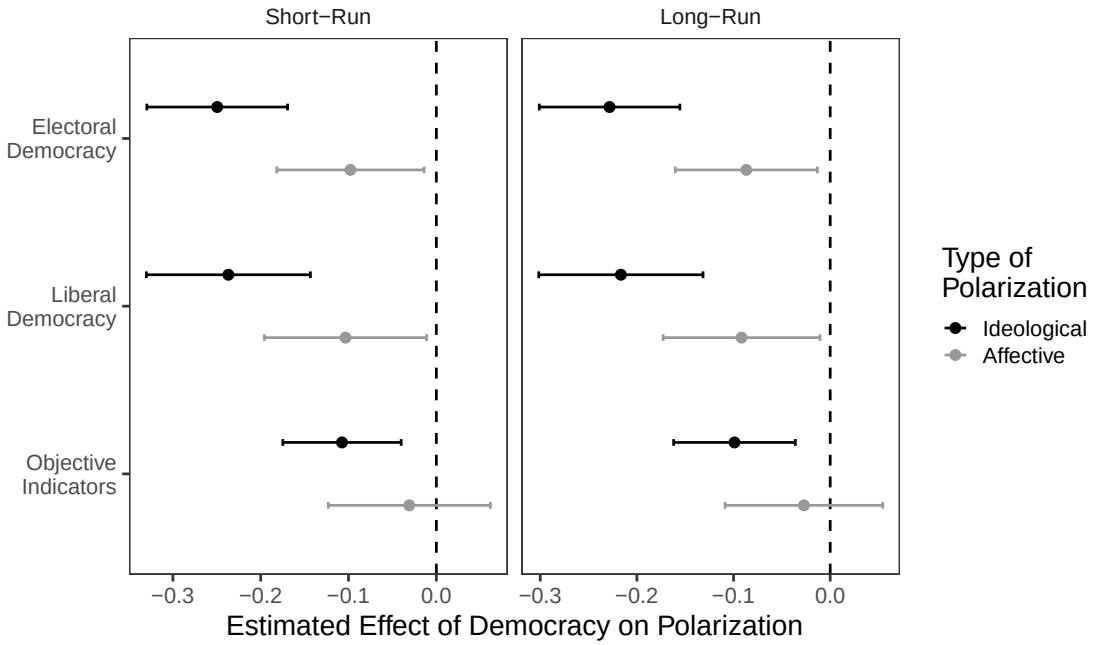


Figure 4: Short-Run and Long-Run Effects of Democracy on Polarization. Long-run point estimates are calculated using (6). Error bars give 95% confidence intervals.

Figure 4 displays a clear set of results: Decreases in level of democracy consistently lead to increases in mass polarization. All parameters on democracy variables carry negative signs regardless of the dimension of polarization or democracy being analyzed, and all but one of those parameter estimates are statistically significant at the $\alpha = 0.05$ level. The one relationship that is not significant—the effect of objective indicators on affective polarization—is also the only relationship that was not significant in the cross-sectional analysis. Further, effect sizes are appreciable and, in two cases, larger than the effect sizes for any other explanatory variable.[14] Comparing the short- and long-run estimates suggests that the effect of democracy on polarization is not ephemeral; it exerts a consistent negative effect, with that effect decaying only slightly in perpetuity.

These relationships are very unlikely to be overturned by time-variant confounding. In SI section S8.2, I show that an unobserved confounder would need to be at least 49 times more prognostic than any current control variable in order to render these effects insignificant. I also show in sec-

[14] As before, all variables are unit-normalized, so parameter estimates can be interpreted in terms of standard deviations.

tion S7.3 that incorporating measurement error into the effect estimates only slightly attenuates the effect, leaving statistical significance unchanged. In section S6, removing countries that experienced coups leads to similar or even stronger results. The preponderance of evidence appears more consistent with mass polarization being causally downstream from democratic backsliding rather than the reverse.

Separating Within- from Between-Country Variation

One theoretical possibility remains unaddressed: Polarization and backsliding could be so intertwined that they exert reciprocal effects on each other. Many scholars acknowledge the possibility of a feedback loop, wherein polarization opens the door for elites to take backsliding actions, but such actions also exacerbate polarization (e.g. Goodman 2022; McCoy et al. 2018). Evaluating this possibility requires me to adopt a different analytical strategy than the one I have used thus far. Instead of identifying each causal effect separately with system GMM estimators, I estimate a random intercept cross-lagged panel model (RI-CLPM). This model allows for a fully specified system of dynamic relationships, including autoregressive structures and reciprocal effects (Lüdtke and Robitzsch 2022).

The model identifies this wide array of effects by decomposing longitudinal relationships into stable between-unit associations and dynamic within-unit variation (Hamaker et al. 2015). The former can produce a correlation, but the latter is necessary (though not necessarily sufficient) to make a causal attribution. For example, political institutions such as democracy are often path-dependent and slow to change (e.g. North 1990). Cross-national comparisons may therefore capture durable differences between political systems, while within-country changes are small, infrequent, or occur on different time scales. A RI-CLPM thus explicitly tests the potential for reciprocal effects as well as the possibility that the cross-sectional link between polarization and democracy is primarily attributable to variation *between* countries, not *within* them.[15]

[15] See Barrett et al. (2024) and Prati (2024) for applied examples.

Figure 5 displays a path diagram of the RI-CLPM, with similar notation to Figure 1. The model estimates latent variables for polarization and democracy at each time point, represented by $\tilde{p}_{ct}$ and $\tilde{d}_{ct}$, respectively. These latent variables are informed by the observed data p_{ct} and d_{ct}, plus covariates X_{ct} (omitted from the diagram) and random error ε. Also informed by observed data are random intercepts for both polarization (RI_p) and democracy (RI_d). As in Figure 1, solid black and gray arrows denote causal quantities of interest. The dotted arrow represents the covariance between random intercepts, and dashed arrows show all other relationships. I allow direct correlation between polarization and democracy at $t = 1$ and correlation between random errors for all $t > 1$. Autoregressive and cross-lagged coefficients are fixed to be equal across all years. I assume the same temporal structure as in (2) and (3) and use the same two sets of covariates from those models, one associated with polarization and the other with democracy.

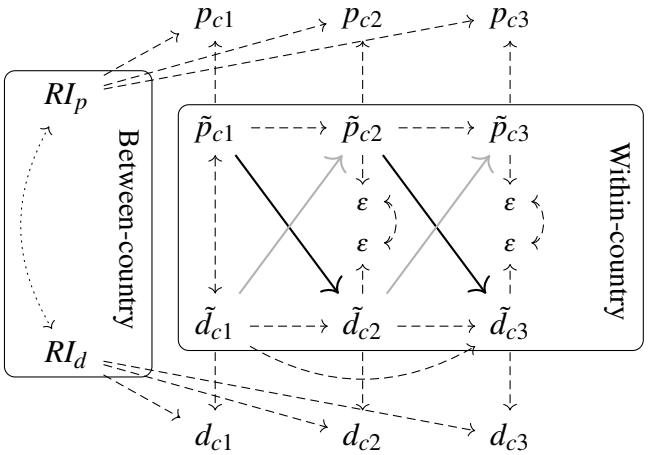


Figure 5: Path Diagram of Random Intercept Cross-Lagged Panel Model. Solid arrows represent causal quantities of interest, dashed arrows represent other relationships among variables, and dotted arrow represents correlation between random intercepts. Tildes denote latent variables and ε is random error. Covariates omitted from diagram.

This visualization clarifies how the RI-CLPM separates between- from within-country variation and allows me to directly assess the type of relationships cross-sectional research has identified. By fully specifying all time trends related to polarization and democracy within each country, I can evaluate both dynamic effects after adjusting for between-country variation. At the same

time, the random intercepts themselves capture stable, country-level traits related to polarization and democracy. By estimating the covariance between those two sets of random intercepts, I can measure the cross-sectional relationship while allowing for within-country changes.

However, the RI-CLPM estimates a large number of parameters, and that number grows quickly with each additional time period. To avoid overparameterization, I only fit these models to twenty years of data at a time, shifting the twenty-year window forward by one year in each model iteration. This approach allows me to estimate the RI-CLPM on the entire time series while keeping the number of parameters manageable and provides an interesting look into how these dynamics have changed since the start of the third wave.

Scholars have cautioned that cross-lagged panel models, more broadly, can inappropriately conflate within-unit effects with between-unit variation in stable traits (Bailey et al. 2020; Hamaker forthcoming). The RI-CLPM is designed to address this issue by introducing random intercepts to model between-unit differences (Hamaker et al. 2015). Bakan (2023) shows this specification dramatically reduces bias in the cross-lagged effects and he notes that modeling latent variables at each time point—which I do here—may further decrease the likelihood of finding spurious cross-lagged effects. Lüdtke and Robitzsch (2022) show the RI-CLPM is unbiased under three assumptions: random intercepts fully and exclusively absorb all time-invariant confounding, within-country dynamics are stationary and correctly specified, and no additional time-variant confounders exist. These assumptions are no stronger than those required by analyses above.

Figure 6 reports the effects of polarization on democracy, effects of democracy on polarization, and covariances between random intercepts RI_p and RI_d. They do so for each combination of democracy measure and polarization type, with lines tracing the evolution of these quantities over the twenty-year moving estimation windows. Since polarization and democracy variables are both standardized and reciprocal relationships are now jointly estimated in a single model, effect magnitudes are directly comparable across all facets of Figure 6. Error bands represent 95% confidence intervals, though I caution that restricting the sample to twenty-year windows makes these confidence intervals larger than they would be if I could fit a model on the full sample.

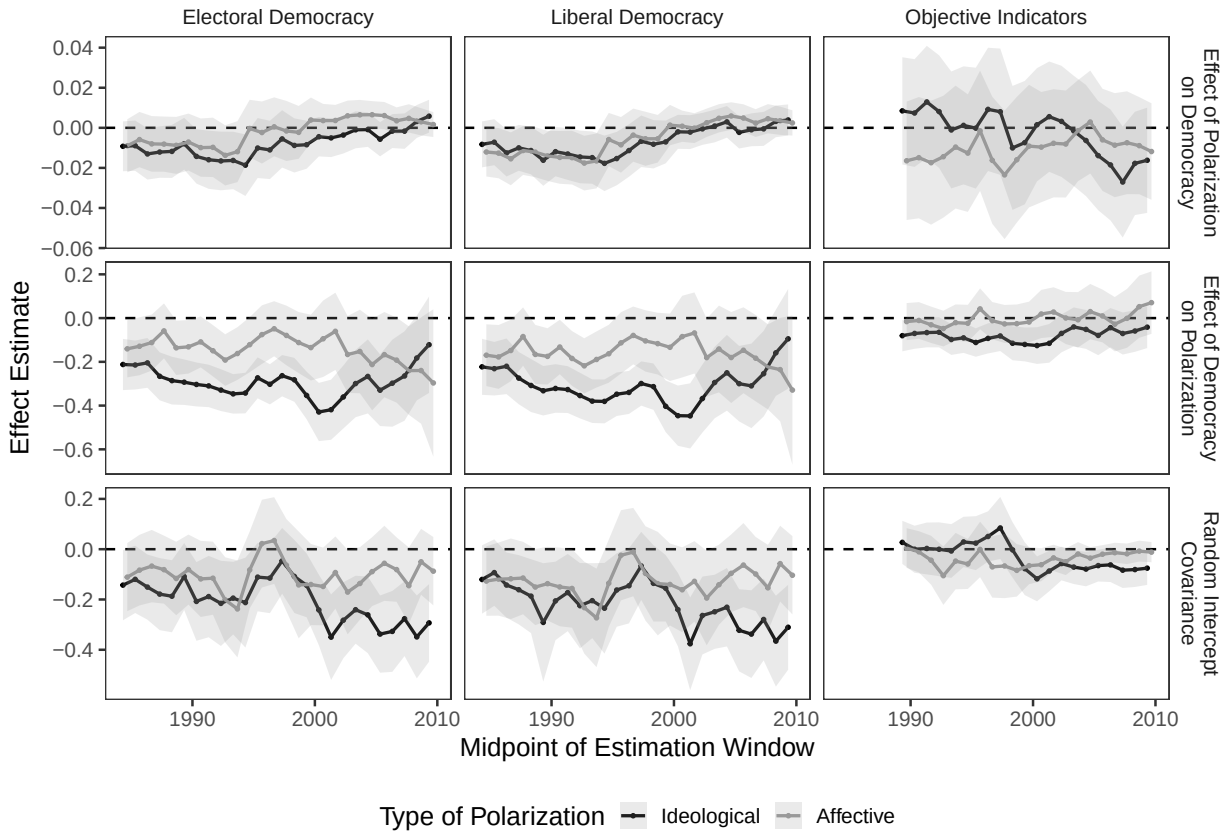


Figure 6: Effect Estimates from Random Intercept Cross-Lagged Panel Models. Models estimated on twenty-year moving windows. Error bands give 95% confidence intervals.

Three main patterns emerge. First, polarization's association with subsequent democracy levels, shown in the top row of Figure 6, continues to be negligible. There is some evidence of a negative association with electoral and liberal democracy earlier in the time series, but coefficient magnitudes are, at most, about two percent of a standard deviation. Approaching the present-day, as global backsliding has grown more acute (Lührmann and Lindberg 2019), estimates approach zero. Affective polarization even carries a positive coefficient over the latter half of the time series, but I hesitate to draw conclusions from such miniscule effect magnitudes. Ideological polarization is associated with lower objective indicator values toward the end of the time series, but associations are not appreciable overall.

Second, examining the second row of Figure 6, backsliding is consistently related to subsequent polarization. Parameters for electoral and liberal democracy are negative and statistically signifi-

cant for most of the time series, with effect sizes more than an order of magnitude larger than those for the effects of polarization on democracy. After estimating reciprocal effects, backsliding still appears temporally prior to polarization. However, associations with objective indicators are much smaller for ideological polarization and effectively zero for affective polarization.

Finally, the bottom row of Figure 6 shows ideological polarization and democratic backsliding tend to covary; countries that are more ideologically polarized also tend to be less democratic. All three models including ideological polarization exhibit negative, statistically significant covariances between the two sets of random intercepts—one absorbing stable, country-level polarization levels and the other democracy levels. Covariances with objective indicators are much smaller, but they are also more precisely estimated. Such stable between-country differences can produce strong cross-sectional correlations, even in the absence of within-country causal effects.

The same cannot be said for affective polarization. Although it, too, covaries with electoral and liberal democracy, those covariances are much smaller in magnitude; between-country variation in these models appears less important than within-country dynamics. Affective polarization's covariance with objective indicators is not appreciable. In conjunction with the similarly small within-country dynamics, it seems most prudent to interpret the relationship between affective polarization and objective indicators as negligible overall.

In sum, separating within- from between-country variation suggests analyses identifying a connection between ideological polarization and democracy may be vulnerable to misinterpreting stable cross-national differences as dynamic causal effects. Such interpretations seem more defensible in the case of affective polarization, but not in the direction that is so often assumed. Viewed in their totality, results in Figures 3, 4, and 6 consistently indicate an effect of affective polarization on backsliding that is dwarfed in size by effects running in the opposite direction.

Discussion

The central takeaway from this study is that mass polarization, by itself, contributes little to democratic backsliding. Rather, backsliding appears robustly related to subsequent polarization. It is important to consider what this finding does and does not imply. Figure 4 suggests changes to democracy affect ideological polarization more drastically than affective polarization. Does backsliding therefore lead the average citizen to adopt more extreme policy positions *qua* policy positions? I suspect not.

Instead, I view this result as speaking to the literature arguing that episodes of backsliding can divide parties over the very meaning of democracy, how to fix it, and whether it needs fixing at all (Corrales and Salas Díaz forthcoming; Mallen and García-Guadilla 2017; Stokes 2025). These conflicts are then reflected in broader belief systems at the elite and mass levels (Layman and Carsey 2002), as parties and individuals align their ideas on the issues with their understanding of democracy and the role of the state. The result is a party system and mass public which increasingly and more consistently identify with "left" or "right." As ideological labels become more politically meaningful, parties and individuals use them to delimit group boundaries and reflect political identities (Conover and Feldman 1981), stoking party affect (Bougher 2017; Rogowski and Sutherland 2016). Democratic backsliding need not push individuals to the extremes on any given issue, but it may set off a cascade of increasing ideological salience and alignment driven by elite messaging and conflict over democratic norms.

The objective democratic indicators give some sense of where greater democratic breakdown fits into the picture. Models using this variable often depart from otherwise consistent patterns, owing to the fact that different democracy measures capture different forms of change. V-Dem indices are better suited for detecting the gradual degradations that characterize contemporary backsliding. Objective indicators are more sensitive to large, sudden institutional changes that differentiate one regime from another, rather than variations in one regime type (Miller 2024).

Accordingly, results suggest ideological polarization is causally downstream from gradual democratic erosion. Combining this insight with substantial between-country covariance indicates

that both processes may accumulate over long periods and therefore tend to co-occur in stable national trajectories. This pattern could manifest as strong causal effects in dynamic panel models—which allow effects to accumulate across a defined set of lags—and as cross-sectional correlations in RI-CLPMs, which separate those correlations from within-country dynamic relationships. Affective polarization exhibits a different pattern, with its relationship to backsliding primarily driven by within-country dynamics. Affective divisions respond more quickly to changes in the democratic environment, intensifying as democratic norms erode. Yet affective polarization appears largely unrelated to abrupt institutional breakdown as captured by objective indicators, suggesting that it increases in periods of backsliding but does not affect the likelihood of regime breakdown.

To integrate all pieces of the puzzle: Ideological polarization is a slow-moving outcome of democratic backsliding; affective polarization is a faster-moving attitudinal response that tracks backsliding without directly causing institutional breakdown. Backsliding—driven largely by elite actions—initiates conflict over democratic legitimacy that gradually reshapes ideological alignments and sharpens affective divisions in the mass public. When institutional breakdown occurs, it is not the direct product of mass polarization, but more likely the culmination of sustained elite-driven erosion that is, itself, responsible for heightened ideological and affective divisions.

Why, then, do so many tests appear to find the opposite? Most identify a *correlation* between polarization and democracy but face significant challenges to establishing causation. Case studies and cross-sectional analyses often struggle to distinguish within-country change from cross-national differences. Behavioral tests—even careful experimental ones—have little to say about macro-level trends; drawing a causal arrow directly from micro-level party affect and democratic attitudes to macro-level democratic institutions risks ecological fallacy (Ahmed 2023). Further, such studies are typically conducted in highly polarized countries, where even individuals with low party affect are embedded in a contentious political environment and may be primed to respond strongly to partisan treatments. It is difficult to know whether citizens would behave similarly in a more politically congenial context (Simonovits et al. 2022).

This work motivates at least three directions for the research agenda on mass polarization. First, ideological polarization has largely fallen by the wayside as affective polarization has garnered substantial interest in recent years. The consistently strong results linking backsliding to ideological polarization suggests the latter continues to be a meaningful aspect of mass politics and merits renewed attention. In addition to more foundational questions about ideological polarization, future work should examine whether particular types of backsliding—such as attacks on the judiciary or freedom of the press—change the form of programmatic disagreement in the mass public, and whether such changes vary with party system characteristics or elite communication strategies.

Second, the evidence that backsliding can drive mass polarization raises questions about the mechanisms connecting them. Elite rhetoric is a natural place to look (Cella et al. forthcoming; Stokes 2025), but even that pathway is likely conditioned by media environments, party system structuration, and the pace and visibility of backsliding itself (Grillo and Prato 2023). How have these effects been shaped by the rise of social media and digitization of civil society? Has the fragmentation of information ecosystems affected the way these dynamics contribute to contemporary backsliding compared to earlier episodes?

Finally, I deliberately isolate mass polarization from other forms, such as elite or party-system polarization. Future work in this vein should acknowledge that polarization is a multifaceted phenomenon (Rostbøll 2025). Its effects may depend on its content; party positions are increasingly structured by new political divides like the GAL-TAN dimension and less by the traditional left-right continuum (Hooghe et al. 2002). Effects could also vary across types of polarization. Mass polarization may follow elite polarization (Cinar and Nalepa 2022), or interact with it in ways that facilitate backsliding even if mass attitudes alone do not. More generally, the average patterns identified here could mask important heterogeneity. Institutional arrangements like electoral systems, federalism, or judicial independence may moderate the degree to which backsliding instigates polarization as well as the degree to which polarization feeds back into further backsliding (e.g. Goodman 2022).

As a practical matter, the findings herein suggest efforts to safeguard democracy by reducing mass polarization may be paying too much attention to the canary in the coal mine and not enough to the carbon monoxide itself. The effectiveness of such efforts may be limited precisely because the polarization they aim to defuse is quickly regenerated by the backsliding already underway. The path to insulating democracy from would-be autocrats may instead run through strong institutional designs, public trust in those institutions, and norm-enforcement mechanisms that constrain elite behavior (Cella et al. forthcoming; Holliday et al. 2025). Democracy is not likely to be saved from the bottom up by moderating mass opinion, but from the top down by strengthening institutions against the elites who would dismantle them.

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